



**POWER DUO**
Kanukuntla Chandrabose, left, and M.M. Keeravani at the Academy Awards; below, dance moves from the winning song, 'Naatu, Naatu'

Music is his life force, his whole being. It offers him a language that words don't. And so, when M.M. Keeravani, 61, took the stage on the evening of March 12 to accept the 'Best Original Song' Oscar with lyricist Kanukuntla Chandrabose for 'Naatu Naatu'—the first song from an Indian film to do so—he ditched the usual script to do what he does best. Instead of the standard bill of thanks to mentors, directors or family, his short, rather simple acceptance speech was a modified rendition of the 1978 Carpenters hit 'Top of the World': "*There was only one wish on my mind/ so was Rajamouli's and our families/ RRR has to win, the pride of every Indian/ and must put me on top of the world.*"

It was a glorious, unusual moment for the world. And yet, for anyone who *really* knows Keeravani, not entirely surprising. An Oscar, a Golden Globe, a Critics' Choice Award and a Padma Shri later—apart from eight Filmfare, one National Film and 11 Nandi awards (one of the highest recognitions in Telugu cinema)—it is only apt to say that as much as Keeravani makes music, music has made him too.

## A LONG ROAD

Born in 1961 in Kovvur in Andhra Pradesh in a Telugu-speaking family, Keeravani grew up listening to Hindi songs on *Binaca Geetmala* and inherited music from his father Koduri Siva Shakthi Datta, a lyricist and screenwriter. He had humble beginnings, starting his career as an assistant music director with Telugu composer K. Chakravarthy and Malayalam composer C. Rajamani in 1987. His first big break was through Tamil film director K. Balachander, who asked him to sing for his 1991 film *Azhagan*. When the songs 'Thathithom' and 'Mazhaiyum Neeye Veiyulum Neeye' received much love from the audience, Balachander promptly offered him his next, *Nee Paathi Naan Pathi* (1991). It was Tollywood where Keeravani really arrived as a music director, where he learnt background music and film soundtrack technique from the late Telugu director and sound recordist K. Viswanath, and where he went on to work with renowned directors like Ram Gopal Varma and K. Raghavendra Rao.

However, despite his growing repertoire, for years, Keeravani remained a faceless genius for the national audience. In fact, he went by three different names when he was first introduced to Bollywood by filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt with the film *Criminal* (1995)—Keeravani in Telugu, Maragathamani in Tamil and Malayalam circles, and as M.M. Kreem in the Hindi film industry. Many were unaware that they were the same person. In Bollywood, even when he delivered hits like 'Tum Mile' (*Criminal*), 'Gali Mein Aaj Chand Nikla' (*Zakhm*, 1998), or 'Awarapan Banjarapan' (*Jism*, 2002), few listeners cared to find out who the man behind those melodies was. But he went on producing music.

Since those years of obscurity, Keeravani's journey to internation-